

macOS Password & Keychain Recovery

Phase 1: Resetting the Login Password (Apple Silicon)

Because Apple Silicon Macs (M1, M2, M3, M4) use a secure architecture, macOS Recovery is required to access the password reset tool.

1. **Shut Down:** Power off the Mac completely.
2. **Enter Recovery:** Press and hold the Power/Touch ID button until "Loading startup options" appears.
3. **Select Options:** Select the Options icon and click Continue.
4. **Open Terminal:** If prompted for a login, click "Forgot all passwords?" or use the top menu. Then go to **Utilities > Terminal** in the top menu bar.
5. **Run Command:** In Terminal, type `resetpassword` and press Enter.
6. **Execute Reset:** Follow the on-screen prompts to deactivate the Mac, provide Apple ID credentials if requested, and set a new password.
7. **Restart:** Navigate to the Apple Menu and select Restart.

Phase 2: Managing the Keychain

Post-reset, macOS will notify you that the "login" keychain cannot be unlocked as it remains encrypted with the old password.

Option A: Resetting if Old Password is Unknown

- Click **Create New Keychain** when the login pop-up appears.
- This establishes a new, empty keychain synchronized with your current login password.

Option B: Manual Reset via Keychain Access

- Launch **Keychain Access** using Spotlight (`Cmd + Space`).
- Select **Keychain Access > Settings** from the top menu.
- Select **Reset Default Keychains**.
- Authenticate with the new password and Restart the system.

Phase 3: iCloud Password Sync

- Go to **System Settings** and select your Apple ID.
- Under **iCloud**, verify that **Passwords & Keychain** is toggled **ON**.

This ensures saved passwords from other devices sync back to the local machine.

Phase 4: Password Export

- Open the **Passwords** app and authenticate.
- Navigate to **File > Export All Passwords...** to create a backup.

SECURITY WARNING: The resulting export is unencrypted. It must be stored on an encrypted drive or in a physical safe.

Technical Notes

- **Intel Recovery:** Use **Cmd + R** during startup for Intel-based Macs. The Terminal command remains identical.
- **Activation Lock:** Password resets do not bypass Activation Lock; owner credentials are mandatory.
- **FileVault:** A recovery key may be requested before terminal access is granted if encryption is active.